Goblin

By Rachel Harrison

Suggested Roles: ***Actress 1:*** *Meg* ***Actress 2:*** *All other Roles:*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

MEG: **(Pg 64-81)** It was Dani's idea to download the Goblin. We were in the dressing room at H&M and she kept sending me out for different sizes.

DANI: None of my clothes fit. I found this incredible dress to wear to Michelle and Ben's wedding, but I don't feel good in it.

MEG: I passed her multiple pairs of the same jeans through the curtain as the attendant disapproved from behind a rack of unwanted clothes.

DANI: I need to lose five pounds. Will you do it with me? I heard it's super easy. You just download the app and you get a Goblin.

MEG: Is it tech or magic? *(to audience)* Some people are good at saying no. Toddlers are good at saying no. I am not good at saying no.

INTRODUCTION

(As if on a weight-loss advertisement)
ACTRESS 1: *Are you tired of weight loss apps that promise results but leave you frustrated?*
ACTRESS 2: *YES! Does losing weight feel like running a marathon on a treadmill set too fast?*
ACTRESS 1: *YES! Well, look no further, glutinous humans!*
ACTRESS 2: *Download your personalized GOBLIN weight loss assistant today!*
ACTRESS 1: *Guaranteed to keep you away from food just when you need it the most!*
ACTRESS 2: *With GOBLIN say Goodbye Chubby, Hello Hubby!*
ACTRESS 1: *Gotta Get a Goblin, today!*
TOGETHER: *Goblin by Rachel Harrison*

MEG: Later that night I thought about calling Dani and politely backing out of the diet. The only problem was my plucky past self had stuffed the RSVP in the mail with the arrogance of a

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white-collar criminal. Four months ago, this was the perfect opportunity to prove to myself that I was finally over Ben. I wasn't feeling so confident now. But it was too late. I'd committed. Chosen salmon over chicken. What would they think if I didn't show? Dani came over to download the app. In ads, the Goblin looked cute and animated. Smurf-esque.

AD VOICE: Gotta get a Goblin!

MEG: It's four ninety-nine? **DANI:** Meg.

MEG: Okay, okay. *(presses phone keys to download; then to audience)* Two tiny green Goblins appeared, each about six inches tall. Dani's was wearing a nightcap and glittery shoes with little bells.

DANI'S GOBLIN: *(twirling, shaking its hips side to side and giving Dani a thumbs-up)*

DANI: *(giggling)* Cute! **MEG:** *(to Dani)* Mine looks angry.

MEG'S GOBLIN: *(arms crossed over his chest, he hisses and shows his fangs)*

MEG: [He] was stocky; his head was shiny and bald except for three thick, curly black hairs spiraling up like springs. And he had fangs!

DANI: He's just serious. Means business. *(to the Goblins)* Hello, little ones.

BOTH GOBLINS: *(Meg's Goblin is bored, taps his foot – then POOF – the Goblins disappear, Dani's Goblin waiving a joyful goodbye)*

DANI: They'll come back when we need them. When we're about to make a bad choice -- like ordering Chinese.

******* later that night*******

MEG'S GOBLIN: *(off stage)* ***Crash. Bang. Slam.***

MEG: *(wakes from her sleep, frightened – she picks up her phone from the nightstand)*

PHONE AUDIO: Hi, Gorgeous! Your Goblin is visiting, doing some Goblin good!

MEG: *(creeps out of her bedroom -- to audience)* The light was on in the kitchen. I paused in the doorway, and there it was, ripping through my cabinets. It poured out a box of Cheez-Its and started stomping, crushing them into orange dust. *(to Goblin)* Hey!

GOBLIN: *(stomps a few more times, then wipes its hand, narrows its eyes, hops over to the fridge and pulls the door open, begins to throw food into the garbage)*

MEG: I watched as the Goblin tossed a chocolate bar into the garbage, along with a bag of frozen

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chicken fingers, a half-empty jar of Alfredo sauce, ranch dip, and a carton of chocolate milk.

GOBLIN: *(dusting off his hands, makes a rude gesture and noise to Meg, then vanishes - POOF)*

******* later that week*******

MEG: *(to audience)* [Hunger] spawned in my gut around 8:30 every morning that first week. My lunch was three plain rice cakes and nonfat peach yogurt. I didn't want the Goblin to come back. [But] on Sunday I went to McDonald's. Fast and dirty. I stood in line salivating at the smell of salt and crackling hot oil. *(wipes the corners of her mouth)* I ordered a ten-piece chicken nugget and ate them on the walk home. I was on my 3rd when the Goblin appeared.

GOBLIN: Hey! *(slaps the nugget out of her hand his voice is gruff and ugly as he begins throwing the nuggets onto the ground one by one)*

MEG: *(shoves the last two into her mouth)* Jerk!

GOBLIN: *(hands on his hips glaring)* B****! *(muttering to himself then disappears - POOF)*

MEG: *(takes out phone while continuing to walk home)* I called Dani.

DANI: *(out of breath)* I'm on the elliptical. What's up?

MEG: My Goblin called me a b****!

DANI: *(laughing)* Mine doesn't say anything. Maybe you get the Goblin that suits you. You respond better to tough love.

MEG: No, I don't. *(hangs up, then to audience)* I moped home and found my workout clothes laid out for me on my bed. The dress for the wedding was hanging on my closet door, slinky and beautiful and ***small***. I saw the Goblin out of the corner of my eye, a smear of green.

******* a few weeks later*******

MEG: *(to audience)* The group text could not be escaped. An invitation to dinner and drinks. I wasn't going. Going would mean a guaranteed appearance of the Goblin, and at least 2,000 calories. I made soup instead. Kale and chickpea soup. I was hungry again in twenty minutes. I decided to make toast. Whole wheat. I left it in the toaster too long and it was dry. *Jam,* I thought. A little sugar-free raspberry jam. But I didn't have any jam. I did have organic coconut spread. It was terrible. I dipped the knife back into the container.

MEG'S GOBLIN: *(appears and knocks the knife out her hand)* Cow! *(disappears - POOF)*

MEG: The toast went into the garbage. I searched the internet for the best juice cleanse. A 6-day

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cleanse delivered to my door. $375.00. If I missed chewing, I could have some celery.

******* a confession to the audience*******

MEG'S GOBLIN: *(stalks around threateningly behind Meg during her confession, he becomes giddy when hearing of her previous eating disorder and his stalking turns into a victory dance)*

MEG: *(to audience)* For me, hunger was nostalgia -- like visiting an old friend I'd forgotten how much I hated. I had overcome hunger before. I knew I could starve. When I was sixteen a few girls went to the guidance counselor, who told my parents, all of my teachers and my soccer coach. It bothered me that everyone knew. It made me feel raw, unsafe.

I didn't understand how it was a surprise. I did damage. I deprived myself. I was a bone. Part of me was hurt that they hadn't said anything sooner, that they hadn't shown any concern. I had to pinch my nose to get the vitamin shakes they gave me down. I imagined what they'd look like coming up. Probably the same.

******* the day of the wedding*******

MEG: *(to audience)* The day of the wedding, Dani and I sat eating mushy grapes out of a plastic bag. I skinned each grape with my teeth and sucked on it to make it last as long as possible.

DANI: Is this going to be weird for you?

MEG: *(laughing)* No. Ben and I were together for, like, five minutes. [He] was always in love with Michelle. It's not like I didn't know. I'm glad they ended up together.

DANI: *(snorts)* You're either a great liar or a much better person than I am.

MEG: *(to audience)* There were violins. Michelle in her mermaid gown, cathedral veil, [with] a collection of pretty bridesmaids. There were vows.

DANI: *(to audience)* He promised to love her always, to put her first, and never to ask her why she needs so many shoes. There were drinks and bacon-wrapped shrimp and mini quiches. There were candles and a taco bar and a pizza station.

MEG: *(to audience)* There was more, but I was too busy willing my stomach to stop howling to pay attention. Salad arrived on art deco china. I unfolded my napkin and reached for my silverware. My hands were shaking. I was woozy. The only solid food I'd eaten in days was the grapes earlier that morning.

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MEG'S GOBLIN: *(whispering in her ear)* ***Are you sad? Are you angry? Are you heartbroken?***

MEG: *(brushes the Goblin away; to audience)* The truth was all I felt was hunger. I skewered a tomato. It was only a tomato. Harmless. *(relishes in chewing)* I had forgotten the simple pleasure of flavor. [Then] I ate the entire entree when it arrived. A slab of salmon pink, mashed potatoes, soft stalks of asparagus. A golden pool of butter gathered on one side of the plate. I sopped it up with a dinner roll. *(blissfully stuffs the roll into her mouth)*

DANI: *(offering her roll)* You want mine? I'm deleting my Goblin. I'm just not gonna eat bread.

MEG'S GOBLIN: *(POOFs in and locks its fangs around Meg's ankle)*

MEG: As soon as I heard "Goblin," the pain registered. I looked down and saw it there, fangs dripping blood. The shame came swiftly. A searing, all-consuming embarrassment. *(to Dani)* I have to go. *(exits quickly to the bathroom and stares at herself in the mirror, horrified)* My skin was sallow, my hair damp. My carefully applied eyeliner was smudged and uneven.

MEG'S GOBLIN: *(takes another bite of her ankle)*

MEG: *(looks down as she speaks to audience)* I couldn't feel anything, but I could hear it gnawing. I could see the small puncture wounds, the thin streams of blood. *(kicking her leg to dislodge the Goblin)* Stop! Please! *(to audience, holding her stomach)* All that food. I ate so much!

GOBLIN: *(opens the door to the bathroom stall and lifts the toilet seat lid)* Do it . . .

MEG: *(sticks her finger down her throat, throws up repeatedly while the Goblin chuckles with glee)* When I was done, it flushed for me. Then stood on the back of the toilet with its arms crossed, looking smug and mean. *(to Goblin, exhausted)* Go away! *(begins to cry)*

GOBLIN: *(arms crossed and very demanding)* Again!

MEG: *(complies, Goblin holds back her hair while she forces herself to throw up again; beat, then to audience)* And I knew. Even if my life were different, even if this were ***my*** wedding day, I would still be alone in the bathroom, hunched over a toilet.*(to Goblin)* I can't do this anymore. I'm deleting you.

GOBLIN: *(snickering)* You can't, stupid. You need me.

MEG: No. I don't. *(stands up and steps out of the bathroom stall)*

GOBLIN: *(growls and lunges at Meg)*

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MEG: *(leans away, narrowly avoiding it; then to audience)* It face-planted on the floor. *(stomps her food down on the Goblin)* I half expected it to have disappeared, but there it was, its little legs snapped in different directions, one eye dangling free of its socket. It was hideous.

GOBLIN: *(moans softly)*

MEG: *(crouches down to examine the damage)* For a moment, I felt sorry for it.

GOBLIN: *(cackles maniacally)* You need me.

MEG: I grabbed it. Flesh. A pulse.

GOBLIN: *(screaming in pain and fear)*

MEG: My grip tightened to stop it from thrashing around. *(squeezes the Goblin until the screaming stops; beat)* I always imagined rage to be a red, chaotic state. But it's quiet and translucent and euphoric. A sister to freedom.

(breaks off a Goblin leg and begins to eat it, speaks with her mouth full) I ate the legs first. They were chewy. *(wipes mouth with back of hand, then twirls back and forth in front of the mirror)* I visualized the way I wanted other people to see me -- really see me-- and know that I was beautiful and that I mattered. . . ***I'll make it up tomorrow -- gym and juice cleanse. Tomorrow.***

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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